



FROST DATES & SEASON

Last frost: May 5 – May 25
First frost: September 15 – October 5
Season: 120–150 days

THIS MONTH — MAY 2026

1. Direct sow peas, spinach, lettuce, arugula, radishes & turnips — soil is workable in April and these need 4–6 weeks before summer heat.
2. Start cucumbers, squash, pumpkins, melons & watermelons indoors in late April (3–4 weeks before mid-May last frost).
3. Plant onion sets and seed potatoes as soon as soil is workable — both handle light frost once in the ground.

QUICK-START CROPS

Brandywine tomato (H)
80 days, full Zone 4 season. The tomato worth growing here.

Sugar snap peas (OP)
Direct sow April, harvest by June, done before summer heat. Highest reward-to-effort ratio.

Detroit Dark Red beet (H)
Direct sow mid-April, harvest July–October, stores months in a cool space.

STORAGE & PRESERVATION

- Canning supplies ready before harvest — Zone 4's August–September canning season hits stores hard.
- Dehydrate herbs (dill, basil, parsley) at harvest peak in July — they bolt fast. 20 min prep, 12 months of flavor.
- Root cellar or garage: beets, carrots, potatoes & winter squash store 4–6 months at 35–45°F. Cure squash 2 weeks first.

ZONE
4

Upper Midwest, Northern
New England, Mountain
Valleys

Minneapolis MN · Burlington VT · Madison WI

HEIRLOOM VARIETY SPOTLIGHT

Brandywine tomato (H)
The benchmark heirloom, 80 days, full Zone 4 season. Pink beefsteak, rich flavor.

Long Island Improved Brussels sprouts (H)
90 days — Zone 4 is just long enough. Frost improves flavor; harvest into October.

Scarlet Nantes carrot (H)
Direct sow April, reliable germinator in Zone 4 soil, 65 days. The heirloom carrot standard.